DRIVE

# PARADISE FOUND

**The Atal tunnel has made it possible to drive to the heavenly Lahaul Valley in winter**

By Yogendra Pratap

If you have ever taken a road trip from Leh to Manali, you might already know that one of the journey's many highlights is the overnight stay. Situated in the Lahaul Valley of Himachal Pradesh's Lahaul and Spiti district, both Keylong and Jispa become options for you to rest your heels. Not only is the Lahaul region around the Baga river an area of pristine beauty, it can also seem like a different world, wholly distinct from the chaos and crowds on the other side of the Rohtang Pass. You'll find here some of the region's oldest settlements. Flying into Leh is a possibility, but that may not afford quite as much fun.

For the longest time, the Lahaul Valley would be totally cut off from the world for the better part of the year. Since Rohtang Pass usually gets the first, and also, at times, the heaviest snowfall, the Lahaul Valley would be accessible only in the late summer or monsoon months. The road to Manali would be the first to close, and then the two other routes—from Lahaul, north to Leh through Baralacha La, and east to Spiti through the Kunzum La—would also get snowed under. The valley, as a result,



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